
The Rules of

Mystic Wood

VERSION 2.0α

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I General description

e canterò di quel secondo regno

And I will sing of that second realm,

dove l'umano spirito si purga

where the human spirit purifies itself

e di salire al ciel diventa degno.

and of ascending to the sky, having become worthy.

– Dante, *Purgatorio* i. 4-6

Mystic Wood is a fantasy adventure for 2 to 4 players, set in an ever-changing labyrinth somewhere between Earth and Heaven.

Each player chooses as his or her champion a Knight, who sets forth from the Earthly Gate to fulfil a personal quest. Moving by turns along twisting paths, the Knights explore the Mystic Wood. In some locations, they encounter the people and creatures who inhabit the Mystic Wood. Through encounters with these denizens and jousts with other Knights, the Knights may acquire strength, prowess, companions, and useful things to help them fulfil their quests. But there are risks as well, including imprisonment in the Tower.

A player wins the game by fulfilling his or her quest and leaving the Wood by the Enchanted Gate. Alternatively, any Knight except Britomart and Marfisa can win by defeating the King and occupying the Castle. Although Britomart and Marfisa cannot win in this way, they have the special ability of being able to ignore the King.

2 Game components

The base game contains the following components:

- 45 large area cards
- 5 Knight cards
- 2 Chivalry cards: Save Boy and Save Damsel
- 32 Denizen and Spell cards
- 4 Knight tokens
- 2 six-sided dice, one red and one white.

In the extension, the following are added:

- 18 area cards, including Altar, Swamp, Temple and Statue
- 2 Knight cards, Astolfo and Marfisa
- 1 Spell card, Mystic Thunder
- 13 Denizen cards, Bear, Crone, Friar, Griffin, Immortal, Nymph, Ogre, Hermit, Sorcerer, Sphinx, Tartar, Tyrant, and Wife.

The rest of these rules assumes you have the extension cards mixed in with the base game.

3 Getting started

Marfisa, sempre a far gran pruove accesa,

Marfisa, always ready to prove herself greatly, stood up,

- *Voglio esser con voi (disse) a questa impresa.*

- I will be with you (she said) in this adventure.

– Orlando Furioso, Canto 18, 102

We suggest that you read sections 1 through 16 of these rules before beginning. You can learn more about individual cards (see sections 17 and 18) as they come up.

Separate the area cards into three groups according to the designs on their backs.

- 30 Enchanted Wood areas (only 22 if only playing the base game)
- 30 Earthly Wood areas (only 22 if only playing the base game)
- 3 fixed locations: Tower, Earthly Gate, and Enchanted Gate.

Lay out the Earthly Gate, the Enchanted Gate, and the Tower face up as shown in figure 1. If playing only the base game, remove the extension cards and remove the left-most and right-most columns in the tile layout figure. Fill in the two halves of the Wood by placing the area cards face down at random, as shown below. Leave a little space between the cards so that each can be turned over without disturbing the whole array.

For purposes of *transportation*, a kind of magical movement that will be explained later, each location except the Tower has a corresponding location

in the other part of the Wood. The numbers in the figure show these correspondences. The two Gates correspond to one another.

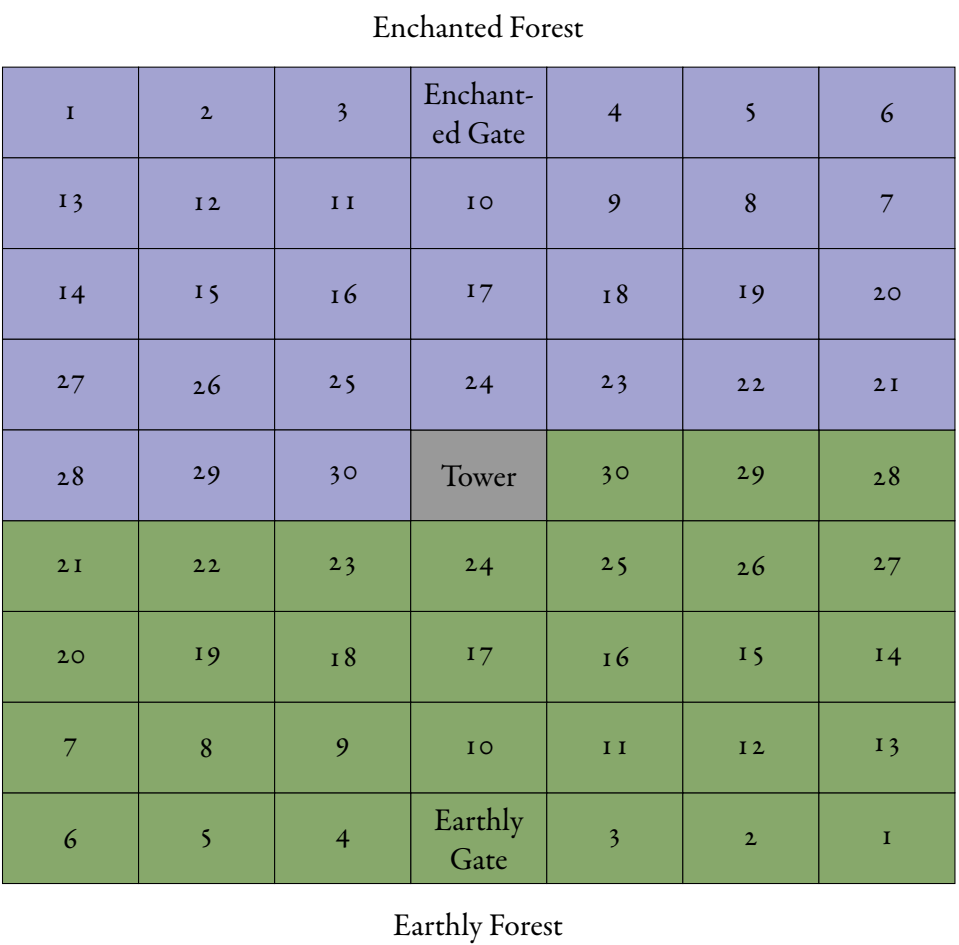


Figure 1: Tile Layout

After the players take their seats around the table, the youngest player examines the seven Knight cards and chooses one of the Knights. The player also selects a token to show the location of his or her Knight in the Mystic Wood, and places this on the Earthly Gate. The remaining Knight cards are then handed to the player on the right, and so on until each player has made a choice. Players put their Knight cards face-up in front of them. The remaining Knight cards and tokens are put back in the box.

Put the two Chivalry cards aside for now.

Shuffle the rest of the small cards and place them face down anywhere on the table.

The last person to pick a Knight is the first player to move, and turns proceed to the left (clockwise) around the table.

The starting player moves his or her token from the center of the Earthly Gate to one of the three paths leading into the Wood. The card adjacent to that path is then turned over. The exploration of the Mystic Wood has begun.

4 Knights

The knight with that old Dragon fights
two dayes incessantly:
The third him ouerthrowes, and gayns
most glorious victory.

– The Faerie Queene, Book I, Cantus XI.

Each Knight has a quest as stated on the card, and an initial power made up of two numbers:

- **STRENGTH.** Shown in the spearhead at the top right corner of the card. Strength represents physical strength, weaponry, and fighting skills. It is used by itself when fighting beasts, and in combination with prowess when fighting Knights and other warriors.
- **PROWESS.** Shown in the circle at the top left corner of the card. Prowess represents wisdom, courage, and glory. It is used by itself in contests with magic-users, and also comes in handy when you are trying to befriend certain Denizens. It is combined with strength when fighting Knights and other warriors.

Guyon, who has less total strength and prowess than the other Knights, is compensated by a special power: he may add 1 to his die roll when greeting any Denizen (see 8.2). Guyon's bonus is not used in fights or in any other die rolls.

As the game progresses, the Knights will acquire companions, things, and extra prowess from successful adventures. Players must keep their cards neatly

arranged and open to view. Cards representing things and extra strength and prowess should be kept under the Knight with their top edges showing. Companions should be kept separate.



George has a total Strength of 6 and a total Prowess of 2.

Figure 2: Character and Inventory

5 Movement

Normally you begin your turn by moving or attempting to move your Knight token. However, movement is voluntary. You are permitted to remain in one place and do nothing.

Movement usually consists of moving to an adjacent area along a path. However, it might consist of exploring an adjacent area and discovering that it cannot be entered from this direction.

5.1 Exploration

To explore a new area, move your token toward any path that leads from your current location to an adjacent hidden area card. Reveal the hidden card and, if necessary, turn it so that the arrow points to the north (the top of the map). If there is a matching path on the new card, move your token onto the area and immediately perform any required actions. If there is not a matching path, leave your token where it was and end your turn.

Regardless of whether you succeed in entering the new area, it is now considered explored and the card remains face-up.

Some areas contain Denizens or Spells. In all areas except the Gates, the Tower, the Palace and the Altar you draw one card. In the Palace and the Altar you draw two. If you have not succeeded in entering the area, place the small cards face-down on the area card without looking at them. Otherwise place them face up and take further actions as described later in these rules.

Cave and Island are special cases. Since these areas can be entered from any direction, your token always moves into the area when it is revealed. However, the small card you draw remains face-down until you or another player actually goes inside the cave or crosses the water to the island. These areas are described more fully below (see [17.3](#) and [17.5](#)).

Small cards are drawn only when an area is first turned face-up. Once the entire Wood has been explored, all the small cards will be in play.

5.2 Movement through previously explored areas

Instead of exploring an area, you can move your token to any adjacent face-up area connected by a continuous path.

If the area contains any face-down small cards, these are revealed. Your turn ends after you have taken any further actions required or permitted by the cards.

If the area you have entered contains no small cards or other Knights, you can immediately take one more move, either exploring an adjacent area or moving to an adjacent area that has already been revealed. In other words, you can take one free move through a previously explored, empty area before taking a normal move.

Exceptions: Any cards inside the cave or on the island, or Knights imprisoned in the Tower, do not prevent you from taking a free move through the area.

You cannot move into the Enchanted Gate and then leave the Wood on the same turn.

5.3 Transportation

From time to time, Knights and Denizens may be transported. This means that they move directly to the corresponding location in the other half of the Wood. For example, transportation from the southeast corner of the Earthly Wood is to the northwest corner of the Enchanted Wood, and vice-versa. Refer to the numbers on figure 1 to see how the locations correspond to one another.

When your Knight is transported during your own turn, your turn ends immediately.

If your Knight is transported during another player's turn, you do nothing further until your next turn.

On your next turn, you explore the destination area (if necessary) and interact with any small cards in the area as usual, and then your turn ends. If the destination area has already been explored and does not contain any small cards or Knights, you may make a normal move, and an additional move if possible (see 5.2).

For what happens when a Denizen is transported to an area occupied by a Knight, see section 8.

6 Spells

Four of the small cards are spells:

- Mystic Fog (see 18.12)
- Mystic Horn (see 18.13)
- Mystic Wind (see 18.14)
- Mystic Thunder (see 18.20)

These cards take effect as soon as they are revealed and are then removed from the game.

7 Denizen cards

Apart from Spells, the small cards represent Denizens: persons, animals, and supernatural creatures who may aid or hinder the Knights.

Some Denizen cards have a second function. For example, the Knight who slays Wild Boar gains prowess. This is shown by inverting the Wild Boar card and placing it under the Knight's card with the "Boar-Slayer" legend showing. Similarly, if you vanquish the Wizard he gives you the Lance, which increases your strength.

8 Meeting Denizens

Quant ele fu leanz antree
 When she had entered there
atot le graal qu'ele tint,
 with the Grail that she held,
une si granz clartez i vint,
 such great brilliance came from it,
Qu'ausi perdirent les chandoiles
 that the candles lost
lor clarté come les estoiles
 their brightness, like stars
qant li solauz lieve et la lune.
 when the sun rises, or the moon.

– Le Conte Du Graal, 3224-3229

When your Knight enters an area that contains one or more Denizens, you usually have two choices: withdraw or approach.

To withdraw, your Knight moves back to the area it came from, and your turn ends. You cannot withdraw if you arrived in the area by transportation, if Mystic Fog has blocked your retreat path, or the area contains no Denizens.

Note: You can withdraw from any Denizen, even one that cannot harm you.

An approach takes place if you do not withdraw. You must also approach a Denizen that has arrived in your Knight's area during another player's turn. In this case you must approach the Denizen in your turn, and you cannot take a normal move afterwards.

A situation may arise where a denizen bounces back and forth between two Knights, neither of whom can move until the denizen decides to remain, befriend, or whatever.

In order to avoid such situations, the following optional rule may be applied: a Knight does not have to encounter a denizen which has just arrived in the area, if the Knight encountered that denizen on his previous turn.

Exceptions: Britomart and Marfisa always ignore the King. Any player can ignore the Queen and Bishop.

If a Denizen transports away from your Knight, then comes immediately back because of an encounter with another Knight, you treat it as if it "remained" on your last turn (see 8.2.1) and you can move on your next turn.

There are two types of approach: *challenge* and *greeting*. You must challenge any Denizen that has strength or prowess, except potential companions (Prince, Princess, Sage, and Grail). All other Denizens are approached by greeting.

8.1 Challenge

To resolve a challenge:

1. Roll the two dice. The white die gives your basic score, and the red die gives the Denizen's basic score.
2. To the Denizen's score, add its total strength and prowess.
3. To your score, add either your strength, your prowess, or both, depending on which powers the Denizen has. Include appropriate bonuses from other cards you hold such as Ox-slayer, Lance, or Horse. See Examples below.
4. If the score is tied, re-roll until the challenge is resolved.
5. If your Knight's score is higher, follow the instructions on the card.
6. If the Denizen's score is higher, you are immediately imprisoned in the

Tower and your turn ends. Your Companions (see 10) are left in the area with the Denizen and become independent again, but you keep all other cards (including Horse).

Exception: A Knight who is vanquished by Enchantress (see 18.7) remains in the area but does not approach any other Denizens. Any Companions become independent.

Examples: Britomart, carrying the Lance (+1 strength), has 3 prowess and 2 strength. She challenges the Orc, who has a strength of 4. Add 2 to her die roll and 4 to the die roll of the Orc. Britomart's prowess is ignored because the Orc has only strength.

Then she challenges the Wizard. The Wizard's score is increased by his prowess of 4, and Britomart's by her prowess of 3. Her strength is ignored.

Finally, Britomart challenges the Saracen. The Saracen's total strength and prowess of 4 is added to his score, while Britomart adds her total of 5.

8.2 Greeting

A Denizen who does not have to be challenged is approached by greeting. Different Denizens react in different ways to a greeting, as explained on the cards. The reaction of some Denizens must be determined by the throw of a die, with the result shown on the card. Strength and prowess have nothing to do with this die roll, except prowess as called for on the Prince, Princess, and Grail cards.

Note: Guyon can add 1 to his die roll when greeting Denizens. He may choose after rolling the die whether or not to add this bonus. This makes him a skilled Horse-catcher, because it gives him more control over the direction the Horse runs in.

The following are the most common reactions of Denizens. For details of other reactions, see the description of individual Denizens (see 18).

8.2.1 Remains

The Denizen remains in the area and ignores you. You may pass freely through this area now or later, but you cannot greet the Denizen again until you have challenged or greeted a Denizen in another area, or jousted with another

Knight. In the meantime you must greet other Denizens in this area (see 9). You cannot take any unowned Things (see 11) that happen to be in the area.

Exception: Queen and Bishop do not prevent a Knight from picking up an unowned thing. The King does not prevent Britomart or Marfisa from picking up an unowned thing.

8.2.2 Transports self

The Denizen goes to the corresponding area in the other half of the Wood. For example, a Denizen in location 16 of the Earthly Wood goes to location 16 of the Enchanted Wood (see figure 1).

The Denizen takes with it any unowned Things (see 11) in the area.

Exceptions: The Enchantress and Grail do not carry off Things when they are transported. Nor do the Horse, Princess, or Dragon when they run or fly away.

If a Denizen is transported to an unexplored area, the area card remains face down. When the area is subsequently explored, the Denizen is there along with any other small cards that might be drawn.

8.2.3 Befriends

You pick up the card as a Companion (see 10) and put it beside your Knight card. The Companion remains with you until called on to part company by some later event.

9 When there is more than one card in an area

Sometimes your Knight will enter an area containing more than one small card. For example, an area might contain a card drawn when it was explored, plus an Arch-Mage who earlier transported himself to the area. In the Palace, two cards are always drawn together.

Multiple spells take effect in the following order:

1. Mystic Horn (see 18.13)
2. Mystic Wind (see 18.14)
3. Mystic Fog (see 18.12)

4. Mystic Thunder (see 18.20)

After any spells take effect, you may withdraw from the area if possible. If you do not withdraw, you must approach all Denizens individually, and your turn is not over until you have done so or have been sent to another place.

First any challenges are resolved, in this order:

1. Denizens who have only strength, in ascending order of strength.
2. Denizens who have only prowess, in ascending order of prowess.
3. Denizens who have strength and prowess, in ascending order of total strength and prowess.

This results in the following table:

- | | |
|--------------------------------|-----------------------|
| 1. Bear, Wild Boar, or Wild Ox | 7. Wizard |
| 2. Immortal or Troll | 8. Sorcerer |
| 3. Giant or Ogre | 9. Enchantress |
| 4. Orc | 10. Saracen or Tartar |
| 5. Dragon | 11. Tyrant |
| 6. Illusion | 12. King |

Finally, if the Knight has won all challenges, other actions take place in this order:

1. Greet Rogue.
2. Greet Arch-Mage.
3. Greet Prince (and resolve challenge if necessary).
4. Deliver Boy, Damsel, or Pilgrim and collect reward.
5. Deliver Crone and collect reward.
6. Greet other Denizens in any order.
7. Pick up unowned Things (see 11).

Note: Unowned things are guarded by all Denizens in the area. For example, suppose you enter the Palace and find Illusion, Elf, and Armour (earlier revealed to be here by Dwarf). After challenging Illusion and vanquishing it, you greet Elf. If he transports himself, he takes the Armour with him. But if he gives you Wand, he disappears and you can take Armour.

10 Companions

The Redcrosse knight to Britomart
describeth Artegall:
The wondrous myrrhour, by which she
in loue with him did fall.

– The Faerie Queene, Book III, Cantus II.

The following Denizens can befriend and become Companions to a Knight:

- Prince
- Princess
- Sage
- Grail
- Boy
- Damsel
- Pilgrim

Companion cards should be kept separately beside the owning player's Knight card.

The following events can cause you to lose a Companion:

- You are vanquished by a Denizen in a challenge. Your Knight goes to the Tower and leaves all Companions in the area where the challenge took place.
- You are vanquished by another Knight in a joust (see [12](#)) and the winner befriends one of your Companions.
- You use the help of Prince or Sage in an approach. Prince is transported, and Sage is removed from the game.
- You rescue Boy or Damsel (see [15](#)). Place the card behind your Knight card as Boy-saver or Damsel-rescuer.

You do not lose companions when you are sent to the Tower after a joust, or when you are transported.

Once separated from a Knight, a Companion becomes independent again and will only befriend after the usual approach.

The Horse is not a Companion and remains with the owning Knight unless another Knight claims it as a prize after a joust (see [12](#)).

11 Things

Objects such as magical weapons come into play as they are given up by Denizens. Once such an object has been taken by a Knight, it remains in play as a Thing for the rest of the game.

The following are Things:

- Armour
 - Golden Bough
 - Key
 - Lance
- 1. Potion
 - 2. Ring
 - 3. Shield
 - 4. Wand

A Knight can carry any number of Things (subject to the rule of Power Limit, see section 14) and can use their special powers any number of times.

A Knight can drop or lose a Thing, in which case the card is placed on the appropriate area card. It remains what it is (for example, Key does not become Rogue again) and can be picked up by any Knight who enters the area, after any necessary interaction with Denizens in the area.

12 Jousts

Il nome mio fu Astolfo; e paladino

My name was Astolfo; and a Paladin

era di Francia, assai temuto in guerra:

I was of France, well-feared in war:

d'Orlando e di Rinaldo era cugino,

Of Roland and of Ronald I was a cousin,

la cui fama alcun termine non serra;

whose fame is without end;

– Orlando Furioso, Canto 6, 33

At the beginning of a turn or after moving, a Knight may challenge another Knight in the same area to a joust.

Note: The Tower area is a sanctuary, and jousts cannot take place there, even between Knights who are not imprisoned.

A joust is resolved just like a challenge with a Denizen. Both Knights add their total strength and prowess to their scores. They may use the aid of Companions.

When you win a joust, do one of the following:

- Imprison your foe in the Tower. The vanquished player keeps all cards, including Companions.
- Take one Thing, Horse, or extra prowess card from your foe and add it to your own hand.
- Approach one Companion held by your foe. For Boy, Damsel, or Sage, this means simply taking the card. Others must be approached with the usual die roll. On a result of “remains,” the Companion stays loyal to your foe. If the Prince responds by challenging and defeating you, he remains loyal to your foe.

The challenging player’s turn ends after the joust is resolved.

After a joust, neither player may challenge the other player to another joust until the would-be challenger has been involved in a joust with a different Knight or a challenge with a Denizen.

Note: For less competitive play, especially with young children, we suggest that jousting not be allowed.

13 Exchanging Cards

Knights in the same area are free to exchange any Things they hold. A Knight may give up a Companion but the other Knight must greet it as usual, and if the greeting is unsuccessful the Denizen responds as usual.

Example: Britomart agrees to give Golden Bough to Guyon in return for a chance to approach Prince. On being approached, Prince challenges her and sends her to the Tower. The Prince card is put back on the map, and Guyon must greet Prince on his next turn.

14 Power Limit

The code of chivalry forbids any Knight to grow too powerful. At the end of any turn when your Knight's combined strength and prowess exceed 10, you must surrender a card or cards of your choice to bring the total to 10 or less.

Prince and Sage, whose aid can be used only once, do not count toward total strength and prowess in this situation. However, Princess, Grail, and Horse do.

Surrendered cards are treated as follows:

- Things are left in the area and remain Things. For example, Lance does not become Wizard.
- Any other cards, including Companions, are transported. Prowess cards resume their original form as Denizens. For example, Boar-Slayer becomes Wild Boar. Any Knight in the area where these Denizens are transported must approach them on the next turn, as usual.

Example: The turn order is Parsifal, George, Britomart. Parsifal, whose combined power is 10, enters an area occupied by the other two Knights. He challenges George (who holds Grail) and defeats him. Parsifal claims as his prize the right to approach Grail, which he obtains, making his combined powers 12. To meet the limit, Parsifal discards Ox-slayer (causing Ox to appear in the corresponding area in the other half of the Wood) and either drops Ring or gives it to one of the other Knights. If Parsifal drops Ring, George can pick it up on his turn.

15 Chivalry

Guyon, by Palmers gouernance,
passing through perils great,
Doth ouerthrow the Bowre of blisse,
and Acrasie defeat.

– The Faerie Queene, Book II, Cantus XII.

Two denizens, Boy and Damsel, are lost in the Wood and want to be rescued.

As soon as one of these cards is revealed in an area entered by your Knight, you fall under the obligation of rescue. This happens whether or not you are

able to greet Boy or Damsel at this time. Just seeing their distress obliges you to rescue them! Take the corresponding Chivalry card (Save Boy or Rescue Damsel) as a reminder of this obligation.

If you are not able to greet Boy or Damsel, the Denizen card remains in the area. If another Knight later enters the area, the Chivalry card is passed to that Knight. Only the last Knight to “see” the Boy or Damsel is under the obligation of rescue.

Example: Roland enters the Palace and reveals Orc and Boy. He withdraws from the area, but he must take the Save Boy card. Then George enters the area, and immediately the Save Boy card goes to him. George challenges Orc, but is vanquished and sent to the Tower. Later, Parsifal enters the area and so George passes the Save Boy card to him. Parsifal vanquishes Orc and greets Boy, who automatically becomes his Companion. Later, Parsifal loses a challenge with Dragon and is sent to the Tower. Boy remains with Dragon (see section 10) but Parsifal keeps the Save Boy card.

If you defeat another Knight in a joust, and your foe holds Boy or Damsel, you do not fall under the obligation of rescue unless you take that Companion as your prize for victory.

To rescue Boy or Damsel you must deliver the Companion safely to the appropriate area; that is, you must have dealt with all Spells and Denizens as necessary. If you greet Damsel in an area that also contains Queen, you can immediately claim the reward for rescuing her.

Example: George has Damsel as a Companion. He enters an area that contains Queen and Wizard. He challenges Wizard and is sent to the Tower. Boy is now a prisoner of Wizard. George retains the Rescue Boy card until some other Knight enters the area, or until he goes back and vanquishes Wizard.

A player who becomes King (see 18.10) is no longer under the obligations of chivalry. If that player has the Rescue Damsel or Save Boy card, the card is set aside and may later go to another player. The King can still have Boy and Damsel as Companions, but he doesn’t have to rescue them.

16 Ending the Game

nemet Roulanten:

Take Roland:

er ist ein helt zu sinen hanten;

He is a very valiant hero;

die haiden furchten in harte.

The pagans fear him indeed.

– Rolandslied des Pfaffen Konrad, 2939 - 2941

A Knight wins the game by leaving the Mystic Wood by the Enchanted Gate after fulfilling the other requirement of his or her quest. A player who has become King (see section 18.10) wins after occupying the Castle as King for one full turn after defeating any Denizens or other Knights there.

Normally the game is over as soon as one player wins, but the other players can continue playing for second and third place if they like.

17 Special Areas

17.1 Castle

This increases strength of a Denizen who already has strength; it does not give strength to others such as Wizard. If two Knights become involved in a joust here, the first Knight to have entered the area is considered to be defending the Castle, and receives the strength bonus.

17.2 Chapel

Your prowess is increased by 1 during any challenge or greeting here. There is no effect on jousts.

17.3 Cave

The cave is a separate place within the Cave area. You may freely enter and pass through this area without entering the actual cave.

The small card drawn for this area, and any other cards that come to this area by any means, are inside the cave. The card drawn for this area is not revealed until a Knight enters the cave.

You may enter the cave if you have the Golden Bough, and you always end up in the cave if you arrive at the cave area by transportation. Once inside the cave, you cannot withdraw but must handle all Spells and Denizens in the usual way. At the end of the turn, if you haven't been sent to another area, you are still considered to be in the cave if any Things, Knights, or Denizens are transported there during another player's turn. Another Knight who enters the cave area by normal movement, and who lacks the means to enter the cave, is not allowed to challenge you to a joust (see 12).

You cannot voluntarily drop anything inside the cave.

Example: Roland cannot leave the Golden Bough inside the cave to prevent Guyon from obtaining it.

17.4 Fountain

Drinking from the fountain is always optional. You can roll the die on the turn you enter (after dealing with any Denizens who might have ended up here) or later. Your turn ends after you follow the instructions. If you end up in an area that contains one or more small cards or another Knight, do nothing further on this turn, just as if you had been transported (see 5.3).

17.5 Island

The island is a separate place within the island area. You may freely enter and pass through this area without going to the island. You can enter the area and go to the island on the same turn.

The small card drawn for this area, and any other cards that come to this area by any means, are on the island. The card drawn for this area is not revealed until a Knight goes to the island.

Your Knight always ends up on the island if you arrive at the island area by transportation. Once on the island, you cannot withdraw but must handle all Spells and Denizens in the usual way. At the end of the turn, if you haven't been sent to another area, you are still considered to be on the island if any Things, Knights, or Denizens are transported there during another player's turn. Another Knight who enters the island area by normal movement can cross to the island and challenge you to a joust (see 12).

Once on the island, a Knight cannot withdraw but must handle all Spells and Denizens in the usual way. At the end of the turn, if the Knight is still in the area, he or she is considered to be off the island.

17.6 Sacred Grove

This increases prowess only of a Denizen who already has prowess. It does not give prowess to Denizens such as Orc, or to Knights and their Companions.

17.7 Tower

At no time will any Denizens appear in this area, except the Horse, which may run here, and Companions. Illusion may not be sent here, nor may the power of Arch-Mage or Magician be directed to or from this area. It is also a sanctuary where no Knight may challenge another.

A player whose Knight is imprisoned in the Tower rolls one die each turn until the Knight escapes on a roll of 5 or 6. If unsuccessful after three tries, the Knight escapes at the beginning on the fourth turn. On escaping, the Knight can move on the same turn.

17.8 Earthly Gate

This is where players begin their foray into the Mystic Wood.

17.9 Enchanted Gate

Any player who has fulfilled his or her quest can win the game by leaving through the Enchanted Gate. This occurs on the turn after safely entering

the Enchanted Gate.

17.10 Palace

Instead of the usual one card, two cards are drawn upon exploring the Palace for the first time.

17.11 Altar

Instead of the usual one card, two cards are drawn upon exploring the Palace for the first time.

The altar is the goal of the Pilgrim's journey (see [18.26](#)).

17.12 Statue

Deal as usual with denizens already here. You may spend two full turns (not counting the turn of entry) without encountering a denizen or jousting, then draw a card on the following turn and deal with it as usual, except that you may not withdraw.

If you do not wish to pray, simply move on; the card can be drawn at a later time.

17.13 Temple

You may choose to draw a card by meeting the conditions, in this case that you discard one extra prowess card; you may not then withdraw. This card can be drawn on the turn of entry or later; meanwhile any other denizens in the area are dealt with as usual.

17.14 Swamp

On each turn after entering, roll a die. If you are unable or unwilling to go in the direction indicated, stay another turn. Any denizens or loose things you find here are dealt with as usual.

18 Special Small Cards

The following cards, in alphabetical order, require some further explanation.

18.1 Arch-Mage

You use his power at the beginning of a turn, and can use it even during a storm. If the destination area is face up and not occupied by a Denizen, you may move out of it on your next turn. But if it is face down or occupied by a Denizen, your turn ends and the usual rules for transportation (see 5.3) apply. If it is the Island or Cave, you end up on the island or inside the cave.

After you use a Companion Arch-Mage's power, he remains in the area where you used it.

18.2 Bishop

You may start praying on the turn after approaching him. At the end of the third turn of prayer, take Ring. You can continue moving on the following turn. If your prayer is interrupted by a challenge or for any other reason, previous turns of prayer are lost.

18.3 Boy and Damsel

See Chivalry (section 15).

18.4 Dragon

Any Knight can challenge the Dragon, but only George can kill it. If the Dragon flees because another Knight vanquished it, it does not take any un-owned things with it.

18.5 Dwarf/Armour

As soon as he is encountered by a Knight, Dwarf disappears from the game and the card becomes Armour, which is placed on the corresponding card in

the other half of the Wood. Any Knight can then pick it up as an unowned Thing.

18.6 Elf/Wand

The power of Wand is used at the beginning of a turn, before movement.

18.7 Enchantress

If vanquished, Enchantress transports herself but does not take any unowned Things in the area.

On escaping from Enchantress, you must attempt to leave by any available path, exploring if necessary. Enchantress ignores you until you succeed in leaving the area. You may not encounter other Denizens in the area or pick up unowned Things.

18.8 Grail

Grail, being more a mystical concept than an object, is not a Thing. After befriendng a Knight it is treated as a Companion (see section [10](#)).

18.9 Horse

When Horse runs, it attempts to move to the adjacent area in the direction indicated by the die roll. If there is no path, it befriends you (you catch it).

You may peek at an unexplored card to see if the path continues in that direction; if it does, turn the new area face up and, if necessary, draw the card(s) for it, face-down. Otherwise leave the area face down and unexplored.

If the Horse runs to the Cave or Island, it is considered to be inside the cave or on the island and always befriends when next greeted.

18.10 King

When a male Knight vanquishes the King, he becomes King and takes that card in place of the Knight card, which is discarded. The player also sets aside any Chivalry cards in hand (these may still pass to other Knights), but keeps all other cards, including Companions, subject to the rule of Power Limit (see section 14).

A player-King is never obliged to rescue Boy or Damsel and does not take a Chivalry card if he subsequently meets either of them. All other rules for Knights also apply to a player-King.

Britomart and Marfisa completely ignore the King as long as no other player is the King. They can approach other Denizens and pick up unowned things in an area just as if the King were not there.

Another Knight, including Britomart and Marfisa, can joust with a player-King in the usual way, and if the King is vanquished, that player is out of the game. If the victorious Knight is not Britomart or Marfisa, he immediately becomes King. If Britomart or Marfisa vanquish a player-King, the King card is removed from play.

When a player-King is vanquished, any of his prowess cards are removed from play. His Companions and Things remain in the area. The vanquisher greets any Companions and then, if possible, picks up Things.

Example: Guyon vanquishes a player-King who has Ox-slayer and Golden Bough. The Guyon and Ox-slayer cards are discarded and the player takes the King card. The new King can pick up Golden Bough, but of course he no longer needs it, since his quest is now to occupy the Castle rather than to visit the cave.

18.11 Magician

If he is your companion, you can use his power at the beginning of any turn. His power cannot be used from the Tower area or be directed at the Tower area. For three full turns after the turn in which he creates a storm, no one may enter or leave the stormy area by normal movement.

18.12 Mystic Fog

Mystic Fog affects only face-up areas marked with arrows in either the Earthly Wood or the Enchanted Wood. Each such card is rotated 180 degrees.

18.13 Mystic Horn

See the rules for Transportation (see 5.3). For the player who draws this card, the turn ends immediately after transportation.

18.14 Mystic Wind

It affects all Things held by Knights, but not Companions or unowned Things.

Remember: Grail is a not a Thing.

18.15 Prince

After giving his help, Prince transports himself. If you approach him again, you must greet him in the usual way.

No prowess can be gained by vanquishing a Denizen with the help of Prince. If a Denizen such as Giant or Saracen is slain with Prince's help, the Denizen card is removed from the game. George may not use Prince's help when challenging Dragon, and no Knight can use his help when challenging the King.

18.16 Princess

When she flees, Princess goes directly to the Gate in the other half of the Wood. She never takes anything with her.

As a Companion, she adds her prowess to the Knight's any number of times. No Knight can use her help when challenging the King.

18.17 Queen

[The following text is added to the card from the first edition:

Always remains.

Once per game you may ask for a boon. 1-4 No boon. 5,6 Sends any Knight you choose to the Tower, or sends you to the Tower area.]

Greeting Queen is optional; you do not have to ask for a boon, even when delivering Damsel. You must be able to approach the Queen when asking for a boon.

If your die roll is successful, Queen immediately imprisons the Knight of your choice, along with his or her Companions and Things, in the Tower. You can instead ask Queen to send you to the Tower area; in this case, your Knight is not imprisoned and can move as usual next turn.

18.18 Rogue/Key

If he betrays you, Rogue stays where he is. Your Knight goes directly to the Tower but you keep all your cards in hand.

A Knight who has Key can escape on the first turn after being sent to the Tower.

18.19 Sage

As a Companion, he gives extra prowess to the Knight whenever the player chooses, but only once. He can be used in either a challenge or a greeting. This card is then removed from play.

18.20 Mystic Thunder

You end up exactly where the following player was. For example, if he or she is in the Cave area but not inside the Cave itself, you end up outside the Cave. In his or her next turn each player must encounter any denizens in the area as usual, and may not withdraw. If drawn with Mystic Wind, Thunder takes effect second.

18.21 Crone

She tells you that she is a maiden under a spell which can be broken only at the Palace. You have the same obligation as with Boy or Damsel. But on reaching the Palace (where you must encounter any denizens) she may betray you; like Rogue, she sends you and your companions to the Tower.

18.22 Friar

He automatically befriends a Knight who has a total Strength and Prowess of 6 or less, not counting that of companions but including Grail, Horse, and all things. As soon as the Knight's total reaches 7, the Friar abandons him or her and stays where he is at the moment.

18.23 Griffin

Until his powers of flight are used, he will follow you as a companion in the usual way. When used, he transports himself from the destination area. He may transport himself inside the Cave but not take a Knight inside. He can be used to escape from the Swamp.

18.24 Immortal

If you vanquish him, he will not keep you from delivering safely the Crone, Damsel or Pilgrim. You must encounter him again next turn if anything happens to detain you in his area, such as the arrival of another denizen. No jousts can take place in his presence.

18.25 Nymph

The Crystal enables the bearer, in lieu of a normal turn, to look at any area card that is still face down, or any small card in play that is face down under the Hidden Cards optional rule (see section 20), or the top card of the pack. If Dwarf is in play, the Crystal reveals the location of the Armour.

18.26 Pilgrim

There is no obligation to rescue him, and you can leave him behind at any time. If you leave him safely in the Altar, he gives you the Staff, which enables you to fight any Knight as if you had equal Strength and Prowess, regardless of any companions etc. the other Knight may have. If you are stronger than the other Knight, simply ignore the Staff.

18.27 Sorcerer

On the turn you vanquish him, he brings to this area any one denizen in play (including a companion) or any one loose thing or thing held by a Knight. You must encounter a summoned denizen in the usual way, on the same turn and in the correct order with any other denizens in this area; but you may immediately take a summoned thing, other than the Grail, which must be approached as usual (see 18.8).

18.28 Sphinx

Guess the throw of a single die. If you fail, you may not try again until you have had another encounter elsewhere, or a joust.

18.29 Wife

The Broth is not a thing, and the extra Strength can never be taken away from the Knight who drinks it.

19 Knights

19.1 Astolfo

In order to “visit” a corner area of the Mystic Wood, he must enter the area, draw if necessary, and encounter. It does not matter if he is vanquished or fails to encounter every denizen in the area, provided he does not voluntarily withdraw.

19.2 Marfisa

On leaving the Wood, she must have personal Prowess of 6 or more, not counting companions but including Grail if she has it. She follows the same rules as Britomart concerning the King.

20 Hidden Cards Variant

For more competitive play, you can use the following rules for exploration.

- When you explore a card and find that you cannot enter it, leave it face down without showing it to the other players.
- Do not draw a small card for an area until you actually enter it.
- Do not reveal the card unless it is a spell or a Denizen you will approach.
- If the area contains a Denizen and you choose to withdraw, leave the card face down.

Remember: You can withdraw from any Denizen. For example, you might withdraw from Druid just to keep Guyon from learning where to find Golden Bough.

21 Questions and Answers

Q: I greet Hermit and roll a result of “Remains.” Then I move to an adjacent area where Queen is, but I do not ask her for a boon. Can I now go back and greet Hermit again?

A: Yes. Visiting Queen always counts as an action that makes your Knight eligible to approach a Denizen again. The same applies to the Bishop.

Q: Can I take a free move through an area occupied only by the Queen or some other Denizen I do not have to approach?

A: No. You must always stop to pay your respects.

Q: What happens if a Knight becomes trapped in a part of the Wood and cannot explore any new territory or leave the Wood?

A: The Knight must wait for relief from some event that might help: for example, the use of the Wand by another player.

Q: Is it possible for the game to end in a tie?

A: Yes. Rarely, a stalemate may occur when no Knight can reach the Enchanted Gate or become King and reach the Castle. It is also possible for a player to force a draw. For example, a powerful Knight who has not fulfilled his or her quest might block the way to the Enchanted Gate and prevent any other player from winning.

Q: Can a Knight drop or exchange a prowess card?

A: No. A prowess card can be taken by another Knight as a prize after a joust, but can never be voluntarily traded. The only time a prowess-granting card such as Wild Ox is put back in play is when a Knight must reduce his or her total power (see section 14).

Q: Can I deliberately leave behind a Companion?

A: No. For example, you could not abandon Boy in the Cave in order to force Guyon to take the Chivalry card. However, nothing in the rules prevents you from making a risky challenge that might send you to the Tower without your Companions.

Q: I'm Parsifal, and Roland has Grail. How can I win?

A: There are only two ways George can lose Grail: (1) he is vanquished by a Denizen and sent to the Tower without his Companions; (2) you defeat him in a joust and claim as your prize the right to greet Grail. Otherwise, your only way of winning is to become King.

Q: Roland greets Arch-Mage and is transported to an explored area that contains a Denizen. According to 5.3, Roland's turn ends before he approaches the Denizen. Britomart's turn is next, and she moves into the area. What happens?

A: Britomart challenges or greets the Denizen. Roland is still too confused by what has just happened to do anything. On his next turn, of course, he

can challenge Britomart to a joust or greet a Denizen who “remained” when greeted by Britomart.

Q: Is it possible to play with 5 players?

A: We don’t recommend a 5-player game, because there are not enough resources to go around, and it becomes difficult to fulfil quests.

22 The Literary Background

The game was largely inspired by two romantic epics of the 16th century: Ariosto’s *Orlando Furioso* (*Mad Roland*) and Spenser’s *The Faerie Queene*. The first is set in an imaginary Europe of Charlemagne, the second in the realm of a certain Queen Gloriana, and both poems concern the adventures of various Knights in search of love and glory.

The poems are immensely long – at that, Spenser’s is unfinished and Ariosto’s just a continuation of another long work by Boiardo – and diverse in matter and mood. At the time of their writing they must have been read aloud in polite circles, a canto a night, furnishing the kind of entertainment later generations have found in novels and television.

The heroes and heroines wander through a sketchily defined landscape punctuated by occasional palaces and cities and peopled with a host of minor characters: wizards, crones, clerics, robbers, royalty, rustics, distressed maidens, and fierce “paynims” or Saracens, slightly resembling the Arab invaders of Europe. The always interesting and often comic encounters of the Knights with these characters and with one another form a succession of episodes only loosely connected by a central theme or plot.

The use of magic in the stories is restrained. True, there are powerful artefacts, like Astolfo’s horn in *Orlando Furioso*, whose sound produces such terror that whole cities flee before him; and in the same poem Rogero has a shield that so surely destroys every enemy who glimpses it that Rogero becomes disgusted and throws it down a well. There are also elaborate illusions, magical fountains, even (in Ariosto) a journey to the moon; but magic never displaces virtue, strong right arm, and trusty charger as the ultimate weapons in the

quest for glory. Mostly it is used by wicked enchanters to turn the Knights from the true path.

Similarly there are few monsters. Spenser's Redcross Knight has his Dragon, who takes three days to overcome, and in Ariosto we find two Orcs – one a blind giant and the other a malignant sea creature who demands the sacrifice of damsels in the appropriate style. But most of the conflict is between humans, and its finest form is the joust, which settles all issues.

The game also owes something to J. G. Frazer's *The Golden Bough*, a monumental study of magic and religion. Frazer's starting-point is the ritual killing of the King in the Sacred Grove, and volumes later he concludes with an explanation of the significance of the Golden Bough that Vergil's hero Aeneas must pluck before visiting the underworld. Fortunately, the book has been published in an abridgment.

A word about the Knights of Mystic Wood. George is of course Spenser's Redcross, from his Book One. Britomart, the subject of Book Three, is one of several formidable lady Knights in the two poems. There are also several journeys to the underworld; the visit to Mammon's treasure-cave made by Guyon in Book Two of *The Faerie Queene* is particularly elaborate. Roland had long been a legendary warrior before Ariosto made him the raving Orlando, lover of the elusive Angelica, Princess of Cathay. Finally, Parsifal or Perceval is the subject of many stories from the Middle Ages and later.

– Peter Donnelly